Consumer Complaint Patterns and Response Trends

Bank of America complaints to the CFPB, May 2017 – August 2023 · Analystlab Africa Data Science Internship

Analytical Report Presented by Shammah Ndubuisi

Overview

Project introduction

62,516 CFPB complaints about Bank of America, 1 May 2017 to 28 August 2023.

Main objectives

Trends, products and issues, company responses, timely response and forwarding intervals.



Key information

A complaint is a consumer report, and it is not necessarily proof of misconduct. Likewise, a response is not proof of resolution.

Method

Data inspection, exploratory analysis and three hypothesis tests with effect sizes.

Headline Statistics

62,516 complaints analysed, May 2017 to August 2023

88.5% of complaints fall in the top four products

96.1% of 61,022 valid records marked timely

79.4% forwarded by the CFPB on the day received

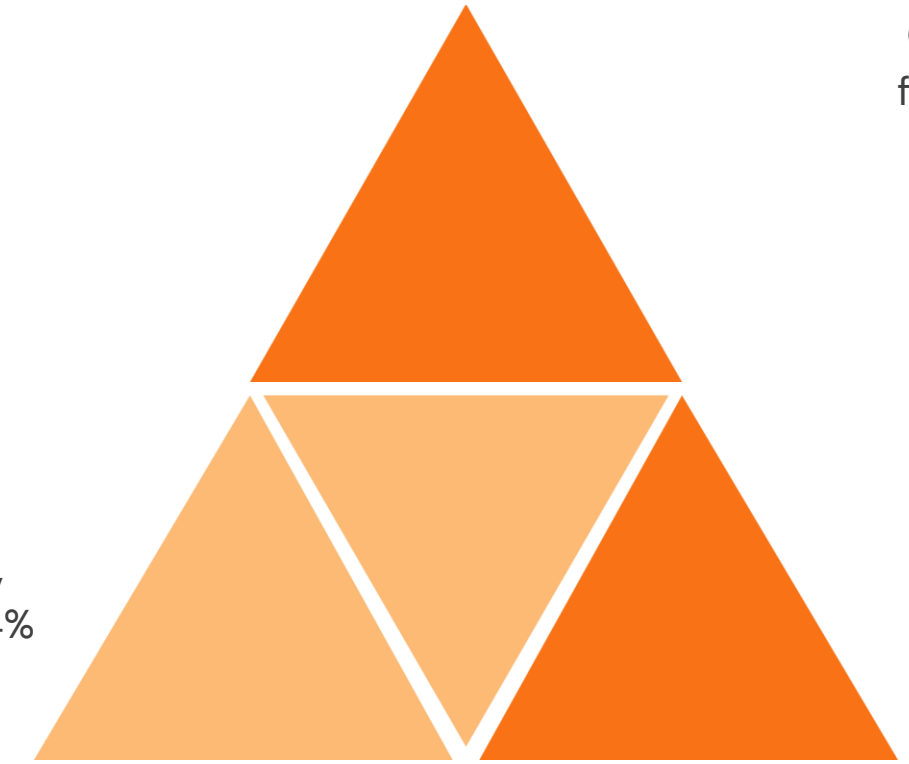
Key Findings

Volume

Yearly complaints rose from 7,872 (2018) to 12,953 (2022). July 2023 was the busiest month (1,749).

Products and issues

Checking or savings: 39.7%. Top four products: 88.5%. “Managing an account”: 24.2%.



Responses

65.7% closed with explanation, 23.5% with monetary relief, 8.4% with non-monetary relief.

Timeliness

“No” rose from about 0.1% (2018–19) to 11.0% in 2021 and 6.8% in 2023.

Statistical Tests

H1

Intervals differ by product, but the effect is small ($\varepsilon^2 = 0.024$) and negligible on Web alone.

H2

Response mix is linked to product (V = 0.21). Debt collection: 88% closed with explanation.

H3

Timely share differs by year (V = 0.21), small only because “No” is rare.

<0.001

p-value in all three tests. Judge by effect size: these are associations, not causes.

Limitations

Reports, not facts

Complaints are consumer reports and responses are classifications, not verified outcomes.



No denominator

Counts are not rates. Several complaints may come from one consumer.

Scope

One company, partial 2017 and 2023, and a CFPB-only forwarding interval.

Definitions

“Timely” and relief categories are undefined, and the causes of the 2021 and July 2023 changes are unknown.

Recommendations

Clarify timeliness

Confirm with the data owner how “timely” is defined, especially for 2021.

Add denominators

Pair counts with customer-base figures so rates can be compared across products.



Split by channel

Report forwarding intervals by submission channel and treat referrals separately.

Show partial periods

Mark in-progress and partial periods, and investigate July 2023 with extra data.

Thank You